

Is this safe? Sorting game

Category	Sorting game - Critical thinking - Table engagement
Skill level	Beginner to run, with food-safety conversation. Anyone can run it with the printed cards and the Volunteer answer key. Expect food-safety questions - lean on the key, and refer tricky ones to a Master Food Preserver. No technology needed for the printed version.
Audience	All ages - Kids, Tweens, Teens, and Adults. Each age group has its own scenarios: kids get simple, observable situations (a popped lid, fuzzy mold); adults get nuanced "it depends" cases. Pick the age on the tablet, or grab the matching age cards.
Setup time	5-10 minutes

DESCRIPTION

Players read a realistic home food-preservation scenario and decide: is it SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS? They place the card (or tap on the tablet) under the matching answer, then flip it for the answer and a plain-language explanation. The "IT DEPENDS" cards spark the best conversations - safety often hinges on one missing detail (the tested recipe, acidity, processing time, altitude, or equipment). 96 cards across 8 topics and 4 age tiers (each card is labeled with its age group).

MATERIALS NEEDED

Digital version (tablet)

- A tablet, charged, turned sideways (landscape).
- Open the game: sign in to the MFP Volunteer Resource Hub, tap "Outreach," then "Play on tablet" on the Is This Safe? card. Use the age dropdown to match the player, and the topic dropdown if they want a specific topic.

Printed version (no technology needed)

- The scenario cards for the age group you need (one deck per age): print "cards-front-<age>.pdf" (the scenario) and "cards-back-<age>.pdf" (the answer + explanation) double-sided - 24 cards each, all 8 topics. Each card is labeled with its age group.
- The three sorting signs from "sorting-labels.pdf": SAFE, NOT SAFE, and IT DEPENDS - placed across the table.
- The "Volunteer answer key" (volunteer-key.pdf) for the full answer, the reason, and likely follow-up questions.

Both versions

- Table, tablecloth, and MFP / OSU Extension signage.
- Optional take-home educational handouts (tested recipes, OSU Extension resource list).
- This Activity guide on the table.

SETUP

1. Decide digital, printed, or both (both is great - printed cards back up the tablet).
2. Printed: print the age deck(s) you expect (Kids / Tweens / Teens / Adults) double-sided - flip on the SHORT edge so each answer lands on the back - then cut them apart. Print the three sorting signs and set them out left-to-right: SAFE, NOT SAFE, IT DEPENDS. Print the Volunteer answer key (all ages) and keep it next to you.
3. Digital: charge the tablet, open the game, pick the age level, and try one card to confirm it works.
4. Put the Answer key and this Activity guide where you can glance at them.

ACTIVITY DIRECTIONS

Running the DIGITAL game

1. Pick the player's age group from the dropdown so the scenarios fit.
2. Invite the visitor to read the scenario on the screen.
3. Ask them: SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS? Have them tap their choice (the three big buttons).
4. The correct answer highlights and the explanation appears. Read it together.
5. Talk about it - especially for "IT DEPENDS," point out what the safety depends on.
6. Tap "Next card" for the next visitor.

Running the PRINTED game

1. Hand the visitor a scenario card for their age group (face up).
2. Ask them to place it under one of the three signs: SAFE, NOT SAFE, or IT DEPENDS.
3. Flip the card over for the answer and explanation. If they ask "why," use the Volunteer answer key.
4. Talk through it and return the card to the deck.

VOLUNTEER NOTES

- Keep the Volunteer answer key (printed, or the explanation on the tablet) next to you - it has the full answer and the "why" for every card, plus likely follow-up questions and answers.
- "IT DEPENDS" is the point, not a trick. The goal is the conversation about what safety hinges on (a tested recipe, acidity, time, altitude, equipment). It is the most valuable card type.
- Accuracy matters: this is food-safety content. Read the answer and explanation as written and do not improvise. Refer harder questions to a Master Food Preserver.
- Match the cards to the player: kids get the Kids scenarios, adults get the Adult ones. Keep it light and fun for little ones.
- No tablet, or not comfortable with it? Use the printed cards and signs - the game plays exactly the same.
- There are no prizes - the conversation and the "aha" moment are the reward.
- Simple tablet help: pick the age, then the visitor taps one of the three big buttons. If the screen sleeps, tap to wake it. If it sticks, close and reopen the app from the home screen. It works without internet once open. Keep it charged.
- Sanitize hands and surfaces as needed.